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Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

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Place Coverage: G/Wi, Ghanzi District, Botswana

Section Title(S): Personal Names

Personal names

G/wi had no name-relationship. Personal names were bestowed to mark some event or circumstance associated with the mother's pregnancy or the birth, e.g. Stint-Me-[of-Tobacco], whose father was insufficiently generous to his mother; Laughing-Steenbok, whose father had a ludicrously unsuccessful hunt (by no means the only one, poor man! — his name is Elephant-Knees because of their wrinkles). The birth of Guineafowl-Peeks was watched by one of these birds displaying unwonted curiosity and boldness. My own name translates as Bluebells. This does not mark my parents' botanical lyricism but derives from the resemblance between the G/wi name for the plant, *dzaundzi* (a plural, feminine noun which becomes a masculine, singular one, Dzaundzima), and Georgie, which the G/wi overheard the poet, Joe Podbrey, call me in unpoetic moments to infuriate me when he visited me in the central Kalahari. (This led to enough tasteless jokes in English; I am grateful they never latched onto Georgie-Porgie, which would have become Dzaundzipa:dzi — He-Bites-Bluebells.) With such freedom of association and absence of gender-specificity it would have been a very rare occurrence for two persons to have had the same name. I could not discover an incidence but it was a hypothetical possibility. I was told that the consequences would have been very difficult; the two people [■57](#) would have shared an identity; they would have to become the same person and, unlike !Kung name-relatives, be linked by much more than kinship.

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